

The Big Feelings Handbook - Printable Cards, Charts and Trackers

From *The Big Feelings Handbook* by Claire Donnelly (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

The Script Cards

Cut along the lines, or print the page and put it inside a kitchen cupboard door where you will see it.

Moment	Say this	Not this
Supermarket floor	"You really wanted it. We're not buying it today." Then stop talking.	"If you stop I'll get you one."
Hitting you	Step out of range. "No. I don't let you hit me."	A lecture, in range, at volume.
Bedtime, fifth time	"It's sleep time. See you in the morning." Same words, flatter each time.	A new conversation about the request.
Homework refusal	"This looks horrible right now. Four minutes, then stop."	"Do you want to fail school?"
Sibling hurt	To the hurt one: "Come here. That hurt." The other, later and privately.	"Who started it?"
Leaving the park	Before: "Two more goes, then we go." After: "That was the two."	A five-minute warning that lasts fifteen.
"I hate you"	"You're allowed to hate me right now. I'm not changing my mind. I still love you."	"Don't you dare speak to me like that."
Late morning	"I know. We're going anyway. Shoes in the car."	A lesson about time management at 8:40.
Night fear	"That feels frightening."	"There's nothing

	I'll check, then sit by the door for five minutes."	there, look."
In front of relatives	Take them somewhere quieter. To the relative: "We're fine, back in a minute."	Performing firmness for the audience.

The four lines to remember

1. Feelings are allowed. Behaviour is not. The answer does not change with volume.
2. Wait for the sound to change before you move in.
3. Say less than you want to say.
4. Repair afterwards, every time, briefly.

My Own Three Phrases

The scripts above are a starting point. Every child has two or three phrases that work better than anything in a book. Write yours here once you know them.

What works with my child	When to use it

The Parent's Early-Warning Card

From Chapter 6. Fill this in once, when you are calm, and keep it somewhere you will see it.

My three earliest physical signs that I am escalating

1	
2	
3	

The thought that tells me I have already gone too far (usually one with "always" or "never" in it)

What I will do in those ten seconds

1	One long exhale - four in, seven out
2	
3	

My exit sentence

"I'm going to stand in the hall for a minute. I'm coming back."

Feelings Vocabulary - Ages 2 to 3

happy - sad - cross - scared - tired - hungry - excited

Feelings Vocabulary - Ages 4 to 6

frustrated - disappointed - worried - embarrassed - jealous - lonely - proud - nervous - surprised - left out

Feelings Vocabulary - Ages 7 to 9

humiliated - resentful - guilty - overwhelmed - insecure - hopeful - relieved - betrayed - anxious

Feelings Vocabulary - Ages 10 to 12

ambivalent - conflicted - defensive - self-conscious - and the full adult range

Underneath "angry", look for

frustrated (I can't do it) - embarrassed (someone saw) - jealous (she got it) - left out (they played without me) - treated unfairly (this isn't how it was meant to go) - powerless (nobody is listening) - worried (and it's coming out sideways)

The Trigger-and-Pattern Tracker

Keep this for two to four weeks before any appointment. The columns are the ones a doctor or paediatrician will ask about, and a fortnight of specifics is far more useful than "he gets very angry".

Date / time	What happened just before	What they did	How long	What helped	Sleep last night

What to look for when you read it back

- Does it cluster at a time of day? (Usually hunger or the end of held-in effort.)

- Does it follow short sleep?
- Is it the same trigger every time? If so, that is a logistics problem, not a discipline problem.
- What is on the "what helped" list more than twice? That is your child's actual strategy - build on it.

The Calm-Corner Planner

Work through this with your child, when nobody is upset. Their answers, not yours.

Question	Their answer
Where should it be?	
What shall we call it?	
Something soft to squeeze or be under	
Something to look at, not do	
Something for your hands	
A drink? A snack?	
Do you want the feelings chart there?	

The three rules, agreed out loud

1. Going there is never a punishment.
2. You can leave whenever you want.
3. Grown-ups use it too.

The Proactive Problem-Solving Sheet

From Chapter 14, for a problem that has happened every day for weeks. Do this at a neutral time - never during the problem.

Step 1 - Ask, then be quiet. "I've noticed [the problem] is really hard. What's up with that?" Then wait through the shrugs without filling the silence with your theory.

What they actually said

Step 2 - Your concern, in one sentence. Short. Not a speech.

Step 3 - A solution we both agree to. Theirs if at all possible, even if yours is better.

What we are going to try	For how long	How we will know if it worked

If it did not work: that is information, not failure. Go round again from Step 1 - usually the obstacle was not the one you found first.

The When-to-Get-Help Checklist

From Chapter 20. Take this to the appointment with the tracker.
Tick what applies.

	Applies
No good stretches - persistently irritable <i>between</i> episodes, not just during them	
School, friendships or family life affected in a sustained way, not one bad term	
Intensity or length far outside the range for the age, and not shifting across a year	
Injuries to others, or to themselves	
Loss of skills the child previously had	
Getting worse despite consistent, calm handling over months	
Any talk of self-harm, or of not wanting to be alive	
Outbursts several times a week for a year or more, with	

irritability in between	
Alongside long-standing inattention, impulsivity and restlessness	
Alongside intense need for sameness, sensory sensitivities, narrow interests	
Fear and avoidance out of proportion, with stomach aches or school refusal	
A sudden change in a previously settled child, following an event	

Any talk of self-harm or of not wanting to be alive is a same-week conversation with a professional, at any age. In the United States, the 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline can be called or texted at any hour.

What to ask at the appointment

What could be causing this physically? (sleep, hearing, vision, pain, constipation, iron)
What is the waiting list, and what should we do in the meantime?
Is there a parenting programme available locally?
If this does not improve, when should we come back?

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